Risk Matrix Reference Guide

How to use this tool

This guide is designed to provide a quick visual of federal agency risk factors used to assess fundamental research proposals and mitigation decisions and how the factors align and differ. Use cases will vary, but may include: pre-award and proposal reviews, hiring reviews, researcher education, detailing degrees of identified risk as part of a research security assessment process, internal risk matrix creation, and more.

Perspectives on Risk

Each agency views risk differently. Color coding has been provided, where possible, to delineate between possible degrees of severity.

- **Prohibited Activity**
- **Mitigation Required**
- **Mitigation Expected/Recommended**
- **Mitigation Suggested**
- **Co-authorship**
- **Links to Entity Lists**
- **BLUE** Blue type indicates commonalities between agencies

Step 1 — **Select the Funding Agency**

The United States Government is a major funding source for research. The agencies below are among the largest U.S. Government funding sources. Each agency operates independently of the others and provides guidance as to how to navigate elements of risk that may be present within a proposal.

Step 2 — **Evaluate the Factors**

Each funding agency views risk slightly differently, and their categorization of risk differs accordingly. Use the information found in this reference guide to evaluate specific areas of risk surrounding your use case.

Step 3 — **Understand the Degree of Risk Involved**

Depending upon the factor and degree of risk involved a funding agency may require specific mitigation methods to ensure both researchers and the research are protected.

Step 4 — **Formulate a Plan**

Each research organization is different. How you choose to move forward depends upon a variety of factors, including your organization's risk appetite and capabilities of dealing with risk in general.

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	Factor 1 Foreign Talent Recruitment Programs	Factor 2 Foreign Funding Sources	Factor 3 Patents	Factor 4 U.S. Restricted Lists	Critical Technologies	Process
Department of Defense (DoD) DoD Matrix: June 29, 2023, amended May 9, 2025 **Considers Risk of:** • **Funding the Project** • **Possible loss of "IP", including pre-published or patented information** View DoD policies, guidelines & resources https://tinyurl.com/5n6jsr5k	**Prohibited: Indicator(s) of active participation in a malign foreign talent recruitment program (MFTRP).** **Mitigation expected if** for the period between 10/10/19 and 8/9/24 indicator(s) of participation in an MFTRP meeting any of the criteria in section 10638(4)(A) of the CHIPS and Science Act of 2022. **Mitigation suggested if** within the 10 years prior to 10/10/19 or for the period after Oct 10, 2019: Covered individual's coauthor(s) on publications in S&E journals are participants in an MFTRP.	**Mitigation required if** indicator(s) that the covered individual is currently receiving funding from a Foreign Country of Concern (FCOC) or an FCOC-connected entity. **Mitigation expected if** received (past tense) funding for the period after 10/10/19 **Mitigation suggested** if for the period of 10 years prior to 10/10/19.	**Mitigation measured required** if patent application(s) or patent(s) not disclosed in proposal, that resulted from research funded by the U.S. Government (USG), that were filed in an FCOC prior to filing in the U.S. or filed on behalf of an FCOC-connected entity. **Mitigation expected** if disclosed. **Mitigation suggested if** not disclosed and a non-FCOC or co-patent(s) application(s) with a person on the U.S. BIS Denied Persons List or entity on the proscribed lists indicated under factor 4 (Entity Lists).	**Prohibited if** research in the DoD project proposal is with an entity or employee on the 1286 list. **Mitigation required if** affiliation* after 8/9/22 with 1. Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) Entity List, 2. the Annex of Executive Order (EO) 14032 or superseding EOs, 3. section 1260H of the FY19 NDAA or 4. section 1286 of the FY19 NDAA, as amended. **Mitigation expected if** affiliation 10/10/19-8/9/22. **Mitigation suggested if** within the 10 years prior to 10/10/19. For the period after Oct 10, 2019: Covered individual's co-author(s) on publications in S&E journals are affiliated with these entities or are on the U.S. BIS Denied Persons List. **Co-authorship is considered.**	Not Explicitly Indicated.	**Risk review of fundamental research proposals recommended for funding.**
Department of Energy (DOE) Office of Research, Technology and Economic Security (RTES) Framework **Considers Risk of:** • **Funding the Project** • **Possible loss of "IP", including pre-published or patented information** View DOE policies, guidelines & resources https://tinyurl.com/3svz73wf	**Prohibited: Indicator(s) of active participation in a malign foreign talent recruitment program (MFTRP).**	"Certain foreign funding sources (both monetary and in-kind)." Dates and types of activity are weighted in the risk assessment.	"Certain concerning behaviors associated with patenting (e.g., transferring to foreign entities after filing)." Dates and types of activity are weighted in the risk assessment.	"Ties to" foreign entities or foreign collaborators on specified lists, "for example", U.S. Bureau of Industry and Security Entity List; Annex A of Executive Order (EO) 14032 or superseding EOs; Section 1260H of the National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) for FY2021; Lists Published in Response to Section 1286 of the NDAA for FY2019 as amended. Dates and types of activity are weighted in the risk assessment. DOE may request confirmation that the relationship has ceased. For past affiliations, associations or collaborations with entities on specified lists, DOE will consider the date the entity was added to the lists as part of the risk assessment. **Co-authorship is considered.**	DOE is unique in that critical and emerging technology areas are the focus of many DOE programs. **If the risk indicators are present on a proposed or existing project, consideration is given to whether the project falls within a critical and emerging technology area,** whether the project will have physical or cyber access to critical infrastructure, and any project work with proximity to a military installation.	Phase 1: A review is conducted on Notices of Funding Opportunities, etc. to ensure language allows applicants to understand the RTES-related requirements and assess the technology risk level of the solicitation. **Phase 2: Before selection, financial assistance projects undergo an RTES due diligence review, with consideration of the technology risk assessment during Phase 1 review.** Phase 3: During the life of a project, additional RTES review may be triggered in situations where there are changes to the project, personnel, or ownership/control that could affect RTES.
National Science Foundation (NSF) NSF Trust Process **Considers Risk of:** • **Funding the Project** • **Possible loss of "IP", including pre-published or patented information** View NSF policies, guidelines & resources https://tinyurl.com/4vv6u48h	**Prohibited: Active participation in a malign foreign talent recruitment program (MFTRP).**	Receiving research support from U.S. proscribed parties: 1. BIS Entity List, 2. the Annex of Executive Order (EO) 14032 or superseding EOs, 3. section 1260H of the FY19 NDAA or 4. section 1286 of the FY19 NDAA and **nondisclosures of sources of research support.**	N/A	**Active appointments and positions with U.S. proscribed parties: 1. BIS Entity List, 2. the Annex of Executive Order (EO) 14032 or superseding EOs, 3. section 1260H of the FY19 NDAA or 4. section 1286 of the FY19 NDAA and Nondisclosures of appointments, activities, and sources of research support.** Co-authorship is not considered.	**Key/critical technologies** identified in the CHIPS and Science Act, beginning with Quantum Information. Potential foreseeable national security applications of the research.	**Risk review of fundamental research proposals recommended for funding.**
National Institutes of Health (NIH) NIH Decision Matrix **Risk Concerns Specific to:** • **Lack of Disclosure** View NIH policies, guidelines & resources https://tinyurl.com/yadt23kv	**Prohibited: Indicator(s) of active participation in a malign foreign talent recruitment program (MFTRP).** **Mitigation measures recommended if** indicators of past MFTRP participation within the last 5 years.	**Mitigation required if** indicators of undisclosed or incompletely disclosed active (ongoing) funding from an FCOC or connected entity. **Mitigation recommended if** a non-FCOC or within the last five years **Mitigation suggested if** within the last 5 years and not a FCOC.	N/A	**Mitigation measures required if** indicators of an undisclosed or incompletely disclosed active (ongoing) affiliation with an instituion or entity located in or connected with a FCOC. **Mitigation measures recommended if** within the last five years or a non-FCOC. **Mitigation suggested if** within the last 5 years and not a FCOC.	N/A	**Review of proposals and ongoing awards.**

*DoD defines affilation as "Academic (not including undergraduate or graduate students), professional, or institutional appointments or positions with a foreign government or a foreign government-connected entity, whether fulltime, part-time, or voluntary (including adjunct, visiting, post-doctoral appointment, or honorary)."

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